



BOLIVIA

Capital cities: La Paz, Sucre

Area: 424,162 sq miles
(1,098,580 sq km)

Population: 8,800,000

Official languages:
Spanish, Quechua, and Aymará

Major religions: Christian
95%, other 5%

Government: Multiparty
democracy

Currency: Boliviano

Adult literacy rate: 87%

Life expectancy: 64 years

People per doctor: 769

Televisions: 116 per 1,000
people

BOLIVIA

THE SMALL, MOUNTAINOUS country of Bolivia has no coastline. In 1883, its coastal region was lost to Chile in the Pacific Wars, and now its main means of export are roads and railroads through Peru and Chile. Bolivia has many resources, such as silver and tin, but its isolated position and many changes of government have kept it poor. About 70 percent of the population is made up of Aymará and Quechua Indians who live on the high windswept plains, called the *altiplano*, growing barely enough food to feed themselves and their families.

SIMÓN BOLÍVAR
Bolivia is named after Simón Bolívar (1783–1830), the Venezuelan freedom fighter known as “The Liberator.” From 1812, Bolívar devoted his life to freeing South America from Spanish control. He liberated New Granada (Colombia), Venezuela, Ecuador, Panama, and finally Bolivia, then known as Upper Peru. Bolívar dreamed of a united South America, but his dream has not come true.



It is cold living on the high plains of Bolivia. The soil is poor. Villagers break up the ground to sow potatoes.



MINING

Bolivia is rich in tin, silver, lead, zinc, and other minerals. Tin mining is an important industry and, even though production has fallen, Bolivia still ranks among the world's top five tin producers. Thousands of people work in the mines, but conditions are dangerous and wages are low. Many miners believe that a spirit, called *El Tio*, lives in the mines, and they leave cigarettes as offerings for him.

LIFE ON THE HIGH PLAINS

Life is hard for the Aymará Indians, many of whom live in villages without electricity or plumbing. Most are poor farmers who grow potatoes as well as corn and barley stalks to feed their cows, sheep, and chickens. Sometimes they have to kill one of their animals for food. Llamas provide wool for warm clothing and llama droppings are used as fuel. Aymará women and girls wear dark green, black, or brown hats.



This lamb will later provide milk for the family.

Many Aymará wear plastic shoes, called ojotas.



FESTIVAL IN THE SUN

Although Bolivia is Roman Catholic, many traditional beliefs still survive. The Isla del Sol (Island of the Sun) in Lake Titicaca is thought to be the birthplace of the Sun and is the location for the celebration shown here. Music is important at Bolivian festivals, when pan-pipes, drums, and brass instruments are played.



Traditional pan-pipes are made from reeds.

COCA GROWING

The leaf of the coca plant is used in the production of the illegal drug cocaine. Coca grows well in Bolivia's mountain valleys and provides a much-needed source of income for local people. The government has tried to stop coca production by offering farmers money to destroy their plantations and grow other crops, such as coffee, cocoa, or bananas, instead. However, this policy has not succeeded, and coca is still Bolivia's main crop.



Loose seeds inside the maracas make a noise when they are shaken.



Maracas are pairs of rattles made from dried gourds.

Find out more

DRUG TRADE: 58

LLAMAS: 58

NATIVE PEOPLES: 43

ROMAN CATHOLICS: 274